MUSC 243 and PSCI 330 Final

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Since the conclusion of World War II, the bilateral exchange of culture, economics, and politics has shaped the auspicious coexistence of Japan and the United States. Michael Auslin's *Pacific Cosmopolitan* examines the conditions that fostered a prosperous connection despite long-standing differences unfavorable for such, as demonstrated as he states: "Yet, in the case of U.S.-Japan relations, where no ethnic bonds or long standing ties existed, there was no natural constituency in either nation clamoring for close contact. Despite this, the modern path of both societies, but especially that of Japan has been shaped by their transpacific engagement."(Auslin 2011, 3). According to Auslin's claim, if America and Japan are truly an odd couple, then how did their strong relationship develop from such unlikely circumstances? From Commodore Matthew C. Perry to General Douglas MacArthur, the dismantling of Japan's insularity through influential figures in the American military opened up a slew of possibilities at first unthinkable. To unravel the mystery of how a resilient US-Japan interchange transpired in light of their differences or unfamiliarity with each other, it should be considered that the unprecedented aspects have been advantageous rather than vice versa. If two countries were identical exchange would be impossible. Therefore, Japan and America demonstrate an alignment in goals and interests, using their differences as an opportunity to learn from each other for further development. I will use the observations and knowledge obtained from my time in Japan, in addition to external sources, to support my claim.

As previously mentioned, the cultural exchange between Japan and America has greatly strengthened their relationship. Auslin discusses this mutual ambition to participate, or even integrate, the traditions and customs of another: "Through the decades, legions of Japanese and American individuals have committed themselves to learning about the other culture and spreading their knowledge through writing, teaching, or performing…"(Auslin 2011, 5). Humans

are curious, so it is unsurprising that two dissimilar cultures formed a relationship based on requited fascination. Some examples of exchange are apparent in the evolution of consumerism in the film industry, technology (computers, cars, etc.), and pop culture trends (social media, fashion, etc.). For instance, the Lolita fashion subculture is a well-known aesthetic with a community of worldwide enthusiasts, including Americans. The style is inspired by the French rococo aesthetic although the subculture itself originated in Japan. With the help of social media, Lolita fashion has been popularized on an international level. I visited a handful of Lolita retailers in Harajuku, Tokyo, and noticed how diverse the customers and shopkeepers were. Regardless of Harajuku's reputation as a tourist destination for foreigners, I believe there is an aspect of inclusivity within the Lolita fashion culture due to its globalization. Its rise in popularity parallels the acceptance of other Japanese aesthetics into American pop culture.

Japan's Ministry of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology (MEXT) encourages American students (and recent graduates) to study and work abroad. This initiative is evident in programs such as the Japan Exchange and Teaching (JET) Programme and the newly implemented Mineta Ambassador Program (MAP). US-Japan exchange programs have shown to be mutually beneficial. To further explain, I will use the JET program as an example. Due to the rapidly declining population, Japan is suffering from a teacher shortage. By allowing certified instructors from the United States to work for their education system, Japan can remedy the teaching shortage in tandem with American teachers gaining new insights and experience in a foreign country. There is a downside to this almost perfect solution. I asked a MEXT employee for her perspective on the teacher shortage. She spoke of the population obstacle but, her response included a secondary issue. In her explanation, the other underlying issue is the lackluster salary for the exhausting responsibilities teachers face. This could interfere with

exchange initiatives like the JET program since its goal is not entirely compatible with Japan's social problems. As a result, American students and employees could feel dissatisfied with these social pressures, rendering exchange programs ineffective or unsustainable in the long term.

I discussed how cultural differences propel a mutual interest, motivating the learning and adaptation of aesthetics, customs, and traditions. However, this raises the question of what exactly the cohesive element drawing America and Japan together is. Japan is a demilitarized nation-state and is limited in combative powers due to Article 9 of the Peace Constitution, which writes:

> Aspiring sincerely to an international peace based on justice and order, the Japanese people forever renounce war as a sovereign right of the nation and the threat or use of force as means of settling international disputes. In order to accomplish the aim of the preceding paragraph, land, sea, and air forces, as well as other war potential, will never be maintained. The right of belligerency of the state will not be recognized. (Prime Minister of Japan and His Cabinet 1947)

Japan relies on the United States for protection from its nuclear weapon-wielding neighbors, hosting almost two dozen military bases as of currently. This military dependency intrinsically cultivates a bilateral political relationship because of an overarching, common goal: to prevent the outbreak of a major conflict. Similar political interests in maintaining peace and ensuring national security allow Japan and America to collaborate, strengthening their connection. However, the emergence of contemporary issues could potentially pose a threat to US-Japan relations. President Trump's plan to place tariffs on Chinese exports could jeopardize Japan's economy. When the first Trump administration enacted tariffs on Chinese goods, Japan was

indirectly affected and saw a 7.6 percent decrease in exports to China a full year after (Yokoyama and Terukina 2025). Assuming his second term in office, Trump's America First agenda may be a liability for Japan's economy, putting the bilateral partnership at risk.

Another contemporary issue that could affect US-Japan relations is the escalation of the banned books movement within American schools. Many pieces of classical literature, which teach important lessons about social issues, are being removed from the shelves of libraries due to the materials containing violent and sexual content, offensive language, and discussion of racial and gender identities. Restricting access to literature could induce a decline in the accessibility to Japanese media, therefore hindering the progress of US-Japan cultural exchange. This is credited to the ideological discrepancy between Japan and the United States on what is considered to be appropriate for children: "However, even in some manga and anime targeted at children and teenagers, there are issues of sexuality and violence that the general Japanese public considers acceptable for younger audiences, while most American consumers probably believe that such content does not belong in children's media." (Phoenix 2006, 3).

Undeniably, the consequences of banning classical literature are arguably the more urgent issue since this is only a hypothetical future in the case the restrictions continue to progress. Keeping that in mind, the implications of limiting Japanese animation and comics could be more disconcerting than expected if it were to become reality. Many Japanese films, especially from animation studios such as Studio Ghibli, express underlying dark or complex themes that hold historical or social significance: "Other Studio Ghibli films such as Nausicaa Valley of the Wind, which contained elements of westernization and post apocalyptic nuclear meltdown, were considered family favorites in Japan."(Frasier 2007, 5). Japanese parents show more leniency in allowing their children to intake media covering darker subjects, while American parents tend to

be more conservative. In fact, most Americans in general do not view Japanese films and animation as tools for teaching mature issues and instead consume them for entertainment or for fictional “escapism” (Frasier 2007, 98).

These changes will not just strengthen or weaken US-Japan relations but, force Japan to redefine its relationship with the United States. The American occupation of postwar Japan has resulted in an unbalanced dynamic. Despite both countries having economic and political influence on a globally recognized level, America can be a control freak: “American and European pressure on Japan to open its markets, reduce exports, and play a greater role in financing third world development may encourage the Japanese to look elsewhere for friends” (Hayes 2009, 308). These micro-managing tendencies could be a residuary mindset from General Arthur MacDouglas’s postwar democratization. The National Film Archive clarified how educational films made in the United States were used as a vehicle for democratization. Portable film projectors, originally used for Japanese wartime propaganda, aided in executing this plan. These “Natoko-eiga”, or American-made educational films distributed by the GHQ’s Civil Information and Education Section (CIE) in Japan, circulated from the conclusion of the war until 1952. There were over 400 of these CIE films. The re-education of postwar Japanese citizens at a grassroots level exemplifies the lengths the United States was willing to go to negate any lingering wartime beliefs. We can examine how receptive postwar Japan was to the instillation of Western values and determine the extent to which this molded the current US-Japan dynamic.

On the surface, it appears Japan has brilliantly endured the strenuous process of modernization, for its “orderly society and technological prowess were the envy of developing countries across the globe” by the 1970s (Auslin 2011, 218). It is undeniable that America's role

in postwar democratization catalyzed the hyper-industrialized version of Japan we are familiar with today. When walking around Tokyo, we can see suits instead of kimonos and McDonald's on street corners in place of fish markets. Japan has ingrained Western influences into its culture but, how deeply are these values intertwined with traditional Japanese beliefs? According to Hayes, there is a lack of spiritual commitment, meaning occupation reforms are not extensively internalized by Japanese society (Hayes 2009, 299). Judicial Passivism is a consequence of this apathetic attitude towards the occupational reforms– which provide the framework of Japan's modern government.

Kyoto University's Professor Tsukasa Mihira conducts research on Japan's court system, particularly on supreme and high court judicial conduct. The lecture explained various theoretical components behind the Supreme Court Justice's change in the exercise of judicial review. He speculates that poor information and time resources were contributing factors in the Supreme Court's Judicial Passivism. Late judicial reform has emerged from educating current justices under the new constitution and greater expectations for judicial roles. Hayes explores a similar, yet more critical sentiment regarding Japan's issue of Judicial Passivism in a broader context: "Especially in the area of civil rights, a vigorous court system is seen not only as the main protector of these rights but as the agency most capable of enlarging and enriching them. Its critics see the court system in Japan as serving the state, not the people"(Hayes 2009, 301). If the direction of judicial conduct changes, then Japan should expect an uprise in the assessment of unresolved social issues. Determining the ban on same-sex marriages to be unconstitutional is an example of addressing an unresolved social issue already confronted in many developed countries.

What would this attitude signify in the context of US-Japan relations? Will the relationship struggle, flourish, remain as it is, or be terminated entirely in the next century? To simplify my earlier response, the overbearing nature of the West on a modernized Japan may cause an inclination to practice stronger self-reliance. These changes have become more apparent in the last decade, as seen in Former Prime Minister Shinzo Abe's attempt to revise Article 9 of the Peace Constitution and in the pursuit of active judicial exercise in the Supreme and high courts. Changes such as these do not necessarily have inherent nationalistic intentions or indicate a future reversion to insularity. Diet member Naoto Sakaguchi of the Reiwa Shinsengumi political party elaborated on this concept in our meeting, as it is a part of his platform. He aims to "normalize" relations with the United States, which he defined as balancing the expectations and influence in the bilateral relationship. An example he provided is the relocation of the U.S. Air Force base in Okinawa to Guam, lessening the presence of American military troops in southern Japan.

Accurately predicting the future of US-Japan relations is incredibly difficult, even impossible. The maintenance of a good bilateral relationship is wholly dependent on the continuation of cultural exchange and the execution of successful economic and political decisions– for both Japan and the United States. These are the ingredients for the close contact Auslin speaks of in *Pacific Cosmopolitan*. Disregarding the formula could impel a deterioration in relations. This would only occur from a misalignment in interests or goals. Therefore, if both countries are satisfied with the nature of their relationship discrepancies will not arise. From the insights gained from my observations and exposure to Japanese culture and politics, I deduced that a change in the US-Japan dynamic– initiated by the side of Japan– is a future possibility. By preserving cultural interchange in tandem with practicing self-reliance (through Judicial

Activism and pursuing peace initiatives/weakening the reliance on the US military), Japanese society can sustain healthier foreign relations while improving upon tenacious domestic issues.

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